

Variable Names

Valid Names

A valid variable name starts with an English alphabet letter, followed by letters, digits, or underscores. MATLAB® is case sensitive, so A and a are *not* the same variable. The maximum length of a variable name is the value that the `namelengthmax` command returns.

You cannot define variables with the same names as MATLAB keywords, such as `if` or `end`. For a complete list, run the `iskeyword` command.

Examples of valid names:	Examples of invalid names:
<code>x6</code>	<code>6x</code>
<code>lastValue</code>	<code>end</code>
<code>n_factorial</code>	<code>n!</code>

Conflicts with Function Names

Avoid creating variables with the same name as a function (such as `i`, `j`, `mode`, `char`, `size`, and `path`). In general, variable names take precedence over function names. If you create a variable that uses the name of a function, you sometimes get unexpected results.

Check whether a proposed name is already in use with the `exist` or `which` function. `exist` returns 0 if there are no existing variables, functions, or other artifacts with the proposed name. For example:

```
exist checkname
```

```
ans =  
    0
```

If you inadvertently create a variable with a name conflict, remove the variable from memory with the `clear` function.

Another potential source of name conflicts occurs when you define a function that calls `load` or `eval` (or similar functions) to add variables to the workspace. In some cases, `load` or `eval` add variables that have the same names as functions. Unless these variables are in the function workspace before the call to `load` or `eval`, the MATLAB parser interprets the variable names as function names. For more information, see:

- [Unexpected Results When Loading Variables Within a Function](#)
- [Alternatives to the eval Function](#)

See Also

[clear](#) | [exist](#) | [iskeyword](#) | [namelengthmax](#) | [which](#) | [isvarname](#)

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